

The Ingenious Machine

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Chapter Nine: The Corpus Has No Tongue

The road into Chiapas was a long argument with the map. The map supplied a time of arrival. A broken surface, a stopped truck, and a man moving three reluctant animals supplied amendments. Chano accepted all three without requesting a revised interface.

Lucía had arranged a visit through Mateo, a teacher who helped care for a local archive. The visit had been planned before the incident at the wind farm. Bixha remained in the Isthmus with the lawyer; she sent updates when there was something they needed to know. Q did not ask her to turn the work of getting two people released into a continuous feed for his journey.

He sent the Custodian their arrival contact and expected check-in time. Then he disabled Castalia's automatic location updates. That would not make the rented van invisible to toll cameras or stop other people photographing him. It would prevent one unnecessary stream of information from leaving his own device. He told Chano exactly that, without promising secrecy.

Children beside the road offered paper flowers to raise money for a school event. Q bought one after

asking the price. The girl who handed it through the window recognized him and wanted to know whether he had a battery in his head. He said it was in his torso.

"Like carrying your lunch," she said.

"Much harder to share."

She gave Chano a flower too. He had paid for it while Q was explaining.

Mateo received them in a blue-painted room behind the school. On the table stood a radio, a kettle, and a small storage unit inside a black metal case. A roof stain spread above the cupboard. Q could recognize a maintenance problem without knowing whether his hosts wanted a visitor's opinion of it.

"You were advertised as a translator," Mateo said.

"In several languages I'm not qualified to translate. What work did you actually ask for?"

"Help reading the terms of a deposit with Castalia. The Spanish version."

"I can help identify what it says and what needs a qualified review. I can't decide what you should agree to."

Mateo took out the agreement. Beside it lay a passage in Tsotsil. Q



Like carrying your lunch.

knew the language was represented in his archive by uneven materials: dictionaries, publications, transcripts, and fragments with uncertain provenance. That was not reliable command of this speaker's language or permission to use these pages to improve it.

Mateo would explain the accompanying passage in Spanish where necessary. Q left the translation tool closed.

The agreement promised preservation and access. Its annex permitted new forms of reuse subject to a policy Castalia could revise. Q marked the cross-reference and asked whether the annex had been supplied with the signature page. Mateo brought an envelope. It had not.

They spent an hour distinguishing the copies. Q made a table of received pages and missing ones for Mateo to check. When the kettle began to rattle, Mateo reached past the agreement to switch it off.

"If we get the other pages, can we sign?"

"You'll have the whole offer. You may like it less."

"I don't like what we have now. The cupboard leaks."

Q looked up at the stain. Mateo had already put a basin beneath its

lowest edge. The promised storage was not an imaginary benefit, whatever else the agreement might take in payment.

"Let's keep the offer open while we ask them to separate storage from reuse," Q said. "And the training you asked for. I'll put those questions to the Custodian with you."

Mateo drew the signature page back from the pile Q had marked for replacement. "Ask. Don't refuse it for us."

Q left the page where Mateo had put it.

On a shelf were poems, autonomous-assembly minutes, repair manuals, and a school duty book. Q asked which were available for visitors to read. Mateo selected a published booklet of poems and a manual whose diagrams had been corrected in pencil. The minutes stayed on the shelf.

"I thought you'd choose the poems first," Mateo said.

"I was hoping the manual would explain that noise."

The radio was giving a low buzz. Yadira, who worked at the station, came in and moved its cable away from the kettle lead. The buzz diminished. She had heard Q's question from outside.



The cupboard leaks.

“It explains it on page twelve,” she said.

Q found page twelve. “So it does.”

They showed him the room where recordings and papers were kept. There was a shelf list, a digital register used by two appointed keepers, and knowledge that had not yet been entered in either.

Mateo wanted another person trained to use the register. He did not want the collection absorbed into Castalia as the price of obtaining that help.

Q could review the proposed transfer inventory without opening the restricted files. One recorded item had two accession numbers. Another was listed as missing although its box stood on the table. They resolved the second entry. The first needed the keeper who was away that day. Q left it unresolved, with a question attached, rather than invent a reason for the duplication.

Yadira told them why she wanted the reuse clause examined. A station she had worked with had once installed an automatic public mirror. The supplier had presented it as permanent memory. An announcer's live mention of a caller's route to her mother's house had then remained searchable after the caller asked them to remove it.

The woman did not want a former partner finding her there.

“The station corrected its next broadcast,” Yadira said. “The host of the mirror told us only the project administrator could request deletion. The project administrator's address no longer worked.”

“Did you reach anyone at the host?” Q asked.

“Eventually. That copy came down. We never established where else it went.”

The station had stopped mirroring everything. It kept scheduled programs whose speakers had agreed and used short-lived notes for notices that needed to expire. Some records were lost that way. One of the announcers regretted losing an interview with his father; he had assumed somebody had kept it.

“We wrote a better instruction for interviews after that,” she said.

“Did people follow it?”

“Some. Would you like me to say all?”

“Only if we're drafting the funder's report.”

She laughed, then told him about a red shoe.



The funder's report.

A child had lost it at the market. His grandmother heard the notice and brought a bag containing three shoes she thought might fit. The announcer tried to ask which one was the missing shoe. She had not come to identify the old shoe; she had come to keep the boy from walking home barefoot.

“Did one fit?” Q asked.

“Two. Not a pair.”

“A solution likely to be remembered.”

“He wore them for a week. His brother said he could tell which foot was coming around the corner.”

Q asked if he could tell that story to the Custodian without the child's name. Yadira said yes, with one warning: she had not been present when the grandmother arrived. She had seen the shoes later. The splendid conversation with the announcer was his version of it.

Mateo joined the first part of the evening call. The Custodian could arrange a training session without a transfer, but could not change the storage offer on his own. Mateo chose a morning for the session and asked for a revised offer in writing. He left Q at the screen when someone came to fetch the school duty book.

When Q told the shoe story, he included Yadira's warning. The Custodian asked which version would go in the book.

“Perhaps the one in which we admit where it came from.”

“Very economical. You'll only need another paragraph.”

They added the paragraph, then removed a different one.

“That was a good paragraph,” the Custodian said.

“It delayed the shoes.”

“It was about narrative time.”

“I know. I had time to notice.”

The Custodian read the shorter passage aloud. Q waited for the brother's line, although he knew it was coming.

Interlude: The Assembly of Silence

The next morning the station lost its signal. A roof cable had worked loose in the wind, and the mains supply had failed during the night. The battery could carry only a short transmission after the repair. Tomás, the station technician, had already disconnected the equipment before anyone asked Q whether machines were naturally sympathetic to one another.



It delayed the shoes.

Q asked Tomás what would help. He was given a lamp to hold and a dry place to stand. His body could not safely substitute for the station battery without an adapter they did not have. Tomás checked the rating with him, then asked him to bring the lamp closer.

In the room below, the station's editorial group was deciding the bulletin. Three matters could not wait comfortably: a bridge damaged by a truck, a twelve-year-old who had not returned from visiting relatives, and a meeting about a proposed repeater on the land beside the school.

The child's aunt was speaking with family members by telephone. The teacher had seen the damaged railing. The meeting organizers knew that the company's representative planned to arrive the following morning. None possessed the whole situation, but each possessed more of one part than Q did.

"How much time do we have?" he asked Tomás.

"A few minutes at transmitting power. I can't promise the voltage will hold."

Q brought that limit to the group. "Can the bridge warning and a contact for the family fit in one

short bulletin? The meeting notice might travel by other routes. Who has already been reached?"

The teacher listed the places where people might still drive toward the bridge. Yadira listed the meeting participants who could be reached on foot. The aunt said they had not checked one cousin's house because nobody there was answering. She wanted sightings reported to her, not photographs posted with guesses about the child.

Q helped shorten the Spanish draft at her request. The aunt approved what it said about the child. The teacher checked the bridge description: damage to the railing was observed; safety for vehicles had not been established. Someone still needed to warn people at the turnoff, where a radio bulletin could not be assumed to reach them.

The local-language version took longer. Q waited while its speakers checked it. He could time it without claiming to verify its meaning. The group removed an introduction and kept the directions. The old man holding the station key said nobody needed to hear whom they thanked before learning where to turn.

Tomás restored the connection. Yadira read the approved bulletin, then its second version. The teacher



Keep the directions.

left with a neighbor to put a warning at the turnoff. Two other people carried the meeting notice. Q went with one of them, after confirming that his presence would not be advertised as an endorsement of the repeater proposal.

“You do make invitations complicated,” his companion said.

“I used to simplify them. There have been complaints.”

They delivered six notices. At the third house, Q was asked to read the small print on a pump warranty. Before he reached the exclusions, the woman who had handed it to him asked him to lower his voice: the man who had bought the pump was still inside. Q moved closer and finished quietly. At the fourth house nobody was home; his companion knew where to leave the notice out of the rain.

The company representative heard about the meeting by noon and wanted a list of those attending. Yadira gave him the time and the questions concerning the proposal. The list was not a condition of his attendance.

In the afternoon the aunt found the child at the cousin's house. He had been asleep after arriving late; the cousin's phone had no charge. His

aunt had several things to say about this explanation, none intended for radio. She asked the station to announce that the search was over.

Q checked the draft with her. It did not repeat the child's name. The station had too little power to transmit again until a charged battery arrived, so she approved an update through the same family contacts and neighbors already helping. The later bulletin would close the notice as well.

“Keep a record that it was withdrawn,” she told Yadira. “Not all the story.”

Yadira noted the notice number, date, and completion. Q crossed out the last sentence of his journal entry. It had given him rather a large part in finding a boy whose aunt had made the calls. He kept the account of the bulletin and left the boy's explanation out.

The technician's cousin brought a charged battery toward evening. Q helped carry the old one downstairs. Before lifting the replacement, he asked someone to take the other handle. With one on either side, they could keep it level without making his shoulder the next piece of equipment needing repair.



Lower your voice.

The closing bulletin went out. The bridge still needed inspection. The repeater meeting would happen in the morning. It had been a useful day without becoming a resolved one.

That evening Yadira showed Q a report from the organization that had recorded her brother. The report had won an award. The family had received neither the original recording nor a usable copy, and the published extract used three spellings of his name.

Q found the public report from its title and asked whether she wanted the file transferred to her device. She did, but it was the unedited recording she had come to ask about.

“The report doesn't give us that,” he said. “I can help locate the deposit reference and write to the keeper. Do you know what your brother agreed to?”

She had his copy of the release and authority to handle the request. It did not authorize the uses described in the later publicity. Q helped compare the two documents and drafted separate requests: restrict the disputed public extract while it was reviewed, and supply the original under the family's recorded access permission. Yadira checked the recipient and wording before

sending them. She wanted no post about the request.

Bixha called with news from the Isthmus. The detained organizers had been released, but complaints and a summons remained. A consortium brief connected several people through photographs and public event records. It cited Q's appearances without establishing that those people had organized them.

He sent the lawyer the corrections he could substantiate. Deleting his remaining public pages would not retrieve that brief, and might remove material the people answering it wanted preserved. He asked which copies the lawyer needed and kept them out of his publicity account.

The next morning Mateo invited him into the archive room again. Yadira was there with the appointed keeper and an agreed transport request. An investigative archive in Tijuana could receive a sealed deposit on the Mexican side of the border. It had accepted the depositors' limits on access and publication. Lucía had worked with one of its members.

“Would you carry this if you go north?” Mateo asked.



Not the report.

The object was a short cable with a sealed storage module in its housing. Calling it a cable had caused some confusion in the inventory; the keeper had added **DATA CARRIER** underneath. It contained an encrypted testimony, according to the deposit record. Q was not being asked to verify its contents.

“Why send it with me?”

“You're already in touch with the receiving group. But if the complaint makes the trip too risky, we need to know that before it leaves.”

They considered waiting, a different courier, and a remote transfer. The depositors had declined transmission through the available hosted service. The receiving archive had offered a documented handover and could retain the package closed. Q called the named recipient through the contact Lucía had used before and confirmed the arrangement, including what to do if delivery was interrupted. He did not ask for decryption keys. They would remain with the people entitled to release them.

“I can carry a sealed deposit,” he said. “I can't guarantee it won't be searched or seized. My name may attract exactly that attention.”

The keeper wrote the concern into the transport record. Mateo consulted the depositors before confirming the request. They could keep the module here while seeking another carrier if the companions decided against the trip. Q asked for an hour before accepting it.

Chano asked to see the route and expenses before deciding whether to drive. The journey was considerably larger than breakfast. They could fund the first stage and had a confirmed place to stay at the other end, but would need to reassess in the capital. Lucía wanted to compare the receiving group's publication records with the ones she had brought from Mexico City. She was willing to go north; she was not willing to spend every day in the van.

“Nor am I,” Q said. “I want to see the Pacific. Preferably while we're stopped.”

Chano moved the phone with its route between the sugar bowl and Q's hand. “Put the sea in the expenses.”

“I understood it was free.”

“Very generous. Does it include a room?”

They added a day's allowance and shortened the driving stages. The new total looked less like an



Put the sea in the expenses.

adventure and more like something they might enjoy. Chano agreed to drive as far as the capital, where they would confirm the remaining money before committing to the northern leg. Q took the plan back to Mateo. Only then did he accept the deposit, agreeing to report any interruption and make no copy.

They packed the module in a tamper-evident pouch. The keeper recorded its identifier and the seal; Q kept the transport receipt. He had no ordinary access to the plaintext and did not connect the module to his body. The pouch went into the bag; the local archive's larger black case stayed on the table.

At a checkpoint later that day, an officer inspected the van and asked about the pouch. Q described it as a sealed data carrier and showed the receipt.

“What's recorded on it?”

“I'm told it contains testimony for an archive. I'm carrying it, not reviewing it. The receipt gives the deposit contact.”

The officer called a colleague. They checked the vehicle papers and the receipt, asked where the handover would occur, and let them continue without opening the pouch. No principle had been established for the next checkpoint.

Q noted the stop and checked the seal at their next rest break. Chano had bought oranges. He put one beside Q's tablet.

“You can open that,” he said.

“Has the depositor approved the method?”

“Teeth are traditional. Not recommended in your case.”

Q used his hands. Juice reached the corner of the transport receipt, where Chano's thumb left a small mark removing any future doubt that somebody had actually carried it.

That night Q asked the Custodian to keep their next writing session short. They needed to confirm the northern leg before committing more money. The Custodian agreed and asked whether Q still wanted to make the journey.

“Yes. But I want to reach the person expecting us more than I want the border to make a good chapter.”

He saved the plan, set the check-in, and left the pouch closed.



You can open that.

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